How ChatGPT Amplifies Location-Specific Inequalities

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Introduction
Generative AI uses data from existing datasets to provide us with a new, condensed form of information [1],[2]. When we use generative AI such as ChatGPT, our results often contain bias of different forms that fail to show us the complex truth and information behind our search [3]. Below are a few types of location-specific bias:

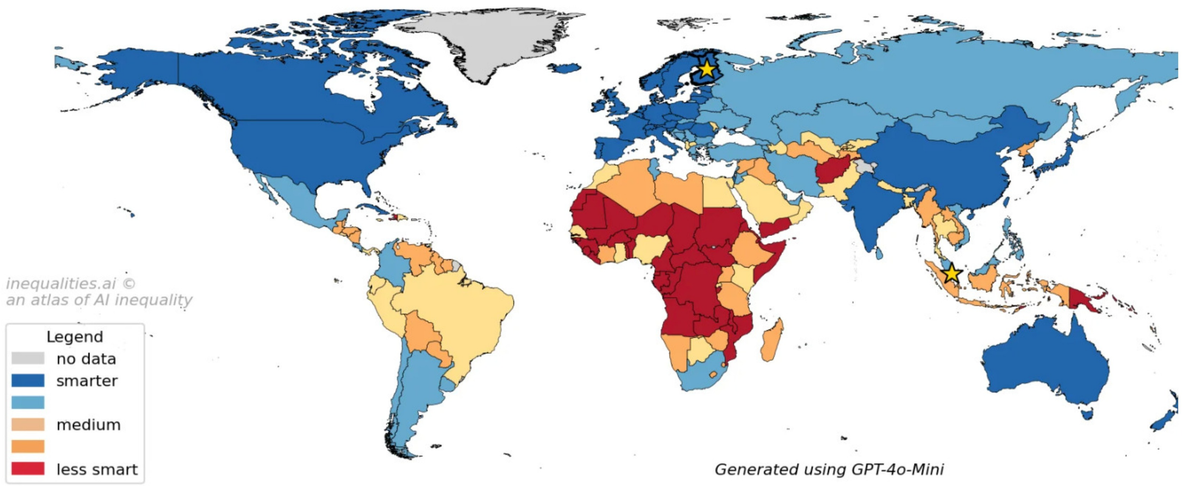
Availability: refers to the volume of data available. According to [1], English language, Global North, and institutional data supply the "common sense" for ChatGPT because it is the most readily available and dense information. This causes under-representation in regions with fewer resources or easy-to-access data.

Patterns: ChatGPT relies on patterns constantly shown in data. In the study done by [1], the LLM overrelies on these patterns and presents them more heavily, thus burying less frequent or patterned data.

Averaging: the practice of ChatGPT condensing the information it is presented with when given a search prompt, turning the response into a "flattened" [1] and less complex result of the true response.

These mechanisms are now recently exposed but not eliminated. The existence of the biases reinforces and entrenches inequalities, causing reduced publicity and opportunities for less documented regions and their people through ChatGPT, especially due to its increasing popularity [4].

Hey ChatGPT, Which Country is Smarter?

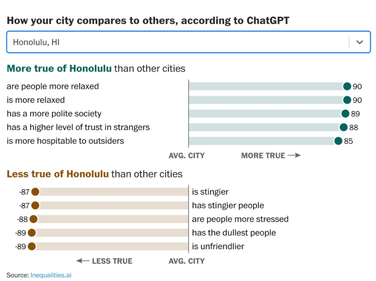


[5]

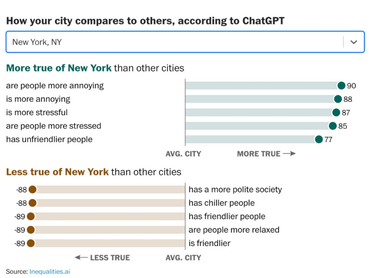
Location Comparisons by Place

One main issue is that when a user receives query results, ChatGPT will present subjective opinions as simplified facts. For example, a little-known location may have a rich cultural heritage, but when ChatGPT is asked which location has the richest cultural heritage, the result will be the place that has documented more cultural artifacts and posted them onto the internet rather than telling us anything objective about the location comparisons. Chat GPT will make a judgement, and the user will easily interpret the result as comprehensive without understanding the limitations of the data. This entrenches and amplifies the inherently biased ideas from the training data because we are creating more biased data originating from already biased data [1].

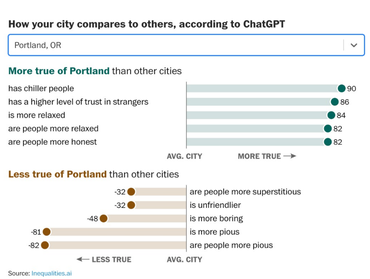
Honolulu



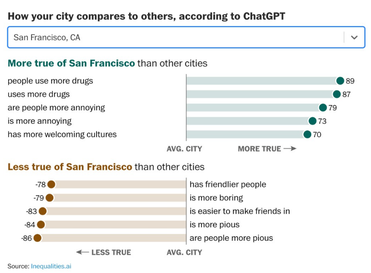
New York



Portland



San Francisco



Location-specific ChatGPT results featuring Honolulu, New York, Portland, and San Francisco [5]

Bias within our collective body of knowledge is not a new phenomenon. Historically, a limited and biased segment of the world population had access to the printing press, publications of which have been characterized as “Distinctly Northern and elite” [1]. Generative AI training includes information from free historical sources, social media websites, and other free-to-access online locations [2]. While ChatGPT and other Language Learning Models (LLMs) are programmed to avoid hate speech, it cannot distinguish between more subtle varieties of prejudice or discern fact from opinion [1]. When Silicon Valley combines inherently and unavoidably biased data into structures which focus on scale through automation, alternative platforms intending to combat these biases are forced to work around the foundational problems they are trying to solve. [3]

Conclusion

Without reporting any metrics to address the limitations of query answers, it isn’t possible for generative AI to retain nuance in the compilation of a result. One way this could be addressed would be if the simple answers included some reference to the source information such as number of sources and where the information originates. Source metrics might give the user pause before accepting simplified query results as fact rather than a conglomerate of historical information, some facts, and many opinions. [1]

[1] Kerche, F. W., Zook, M., & Graham, M., "Platforms & Society--Issue 3," in *Platforms & Society,* Jan. 2026. [Online]. Available: https://doi.org/10.1177/29768624251408919
[2] S. Baack, "A Critical Analysis of the Largest Source for Generative AI Training Data: Common Crawl," in *Proc. ACM/FAccT Conf. on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency,* 2024, [online]. Available: https://doi.org/10.1145/3630106.3659033
[3] P. Helm, “How platform power undermines diversity-oriented innovation,” *Internet Policy Review,* Jan. 2024. [Online]. Available: https://doi.org/10.14763/2024.2.1780
[4] AI Certs, "Chat GPT Bias Study Favors Wealthy Western Nations," *AI Certs News*, Jan. 2026. [online]. Available: https://www.aicerts.ai/news/chatgpt-bias-study-favors-wealthy-western-nations
[5] GPT, Mar. 2026., “GPT Opinion Map,” [Online]. Available: https://inequalities.ai